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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Chicago's US attorney's office at crossroads

Indictments dip; search for leader underway

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

The search for Chicago's 42nd U.S. attorney comes at a significant moment in history for an office long extolled as a model for the nation.

After two years without a Senate-confirmed top federal

prosecutor, the office has seen its productivity go into free fall, putting it behind much smaller outposts such as Rhode Island and even tiny Guam when it comes to key metrics kept by the district courts, records show.

Through the turmoil of changing administrations and a global pandemic, scores of veteran prosecutors fled for private practice or judgeships, leaving large gaps in leadership. Morale has dipped amid a variety of issues, sources

told the Tribune, including COVID-era hybrid work schedules that limited face-to-face time, a focus on one-off gun cases, and now a federal hiring freeze.

The bleeding continued last week, with the announcement that Assistant U.S. Attorney Amarjeet Bhachu, the veteran boss of the Public Corruption and Organized Crime Section who led the prosecution of ex-Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan, is leaving Friday.

Now, an emboldened President Donald Trump is keeping good on his promise to remake the U.S. Justice Department, selecting loyalists Pam Bondi as attorney general and Kash Patel as FBI director and dramatically shifting priorities away from some of the more traditional investigative targets in Illinois.

Other moves, such as the attempt to drop the corruption case against New York Mayor Eric Adams, which led to mass resigna-

tions of prosecutors in New York and Washington, have had ripple effects in Chicago as well, putting many, especially younger line attorneys, on edge. On Friday, two federal prosecutors in Manhattan who worked on the Adams case were placed on leave and escorted out of the building by federal law enforcement, according to multiple news reports.

The galvanizing issues have

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The former Dwight Correctional Center sits on 160 acres on Thursday in Dwight, Ill. It includes dozens of buildings, many constructed in the French Norman style and built with yellow brick and stone. The women's prison opened in 1930 and was closed in 2013. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Eyesores and empty shells

Gov. Pritzker's \$300 million proposal seeks to attract developers to 5 abandoned state-owned sites that now draw little more than vandals

By Jeremy Gorner and Olivia Olander | Chicago Tribune

DWIGHT, Ill. — Nature has taken over the vacated Dwight Correctional Center, where a thin forest of spindly trees covers a 160-acre campus that old photos show once featured well-tended lawns and stately oaks.

The decaying old prison has become an unauthorized soundstage for YouTubers. In a video titled "We Got Trapped Inside an Abandoned Prison by Police," a user whose profile promises "crazy abandoned explorations!" describes wandering the off-limits site for hours before encountering a police officer.

"After spending hours here and not seeing anyone but us, we realized we weren't here by ourselves. Someone was watching and listening," a narrator says over foreboding music.

On a recent visit, the scene at the prison that closed more than 10 years ago and has been largely left

to deteriorate was more mundane. The prison's buildings sit on a rural patch just off Interstate 55, abutting farm fields, a small cemetery and the west fork of the Mazon River, just west of the town of about 4,000 inhabitants.

If the General Assembly approves a key element of Gov. JB Pritzker's budget proposal this spring, it could breathe life back into the sprawling, overgrown site and four other unused state properties like it that have become targets for vandalism and worse.

In a budget proposal that included no new taxes and cuts to key programs like health care for non-citizen immigrants, Pritzker is proposing the state invest \$300 million to prepare the sites for private development. Funding would come from the state's capital budget.

The Pritzker administration said the program would create jobs and support community revitalization,

and the project would attract new businesses, potentially leading to billions of dollars in private investment. The five sites in the proposal were identified as "high priority," though others might be considered in the future.

"There's no reason for the state to continue to own that facility. Let's see if there's a private owner that would take that over, that we could sell that facility to. So maybe it takes a little bit of money," Pritzker said Thursday during an unrelated news conference in Champaign. "Nobody wants to buy an old prison, for example, to use for something. And so sometimes you have to tear down what's on the property to make it of any value to a future owner and so we're looking at all that."

In addition to the Dwight prison, the proposal includes the site of

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\$11M payout reached in DuPage jail death

County, sheriff settle with estate of woman whose death was attributed in part to 'medical neglect'

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

DuPage County and county Sheriff James Mendrick have reached an \$11 million settlement with the estate of Reneyda Aguilar-Hurtado, a 50-year-old mother who died in June 2023 after being held in the county jail for 85 days while awaiting transfer to a state-run mental health center.

Approved by a judge last month, the settlement caps a federal lawsuit brought by Aguilar-Hurtado's daughter, Cristal Moreno Aguilar, accusing the county, Mendrick and 11 jail medical staff members or corrections officers of repeatedly failing to act as her mother's health rapidly deteriorated.

A county pathologist determined her death was due, in part, to "medical neglect."

The nearly 50-page complaint, filed a month after Aguilar-Hurtado's death, cited about a dozen examples of other jail detainees — some who died while on medical watch, others who have sued the jail over health care complaints — in alleging a "widespread practice and policy of deliberate indifference to the health and safety of critically ill inmates suffering from life-threatening conditions under their custody and control."

Mendrick, who recently announced his intent to forgo a third term as sheriff and instead seek the Republican nomination

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Cristal Moreno Aguilar stands at Augustana College on Oct. 8 in Rock Island, Ill. Aguilar's mother, Reneyda Aguilar-Hurtado, died on June 12, 2023, in DuPage County Jail, after being incarcerated for 85 days.

ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

INSIDE

Panama releases US deportees, gives them exit deadline

After weeks of lawsuits and human rights criticism, the Central American nation released dozens of migrants who were held for weeks in a remote camp, telling them they have 30 days to leave.

Nation & World

Chicago sets dates for Blues Fest, Taste, other events

This summer's schedule of music festivals and city events was announced, including the return of Blues Fest, Jazz Fest and other favorites. The announcement extends beyond summer and includes New Year's Eve. **Arts & Living**

